

PRACTICAL MANUAL GUIDE

Step by step guide on how to frame your screen for design

By

Oluwaseun Ayanyemi

This Workbook belongs to :

Welcome aboard!

Welcome to *Creating the Grid System*, a practical workbook designed to turn chaotic layouts into clean, confident, and cohesive designs.

Whether you are a beginner struggling with alignment or a seasoned designer looking to systematize your workflow, this workbook will give you the structure you need. No theory overload. Just actionable steps, visual exercises, and real layout challenges.

Mastering the Grid

Grids are the invisible backbone of great design. They bring order to creativity, helping you:

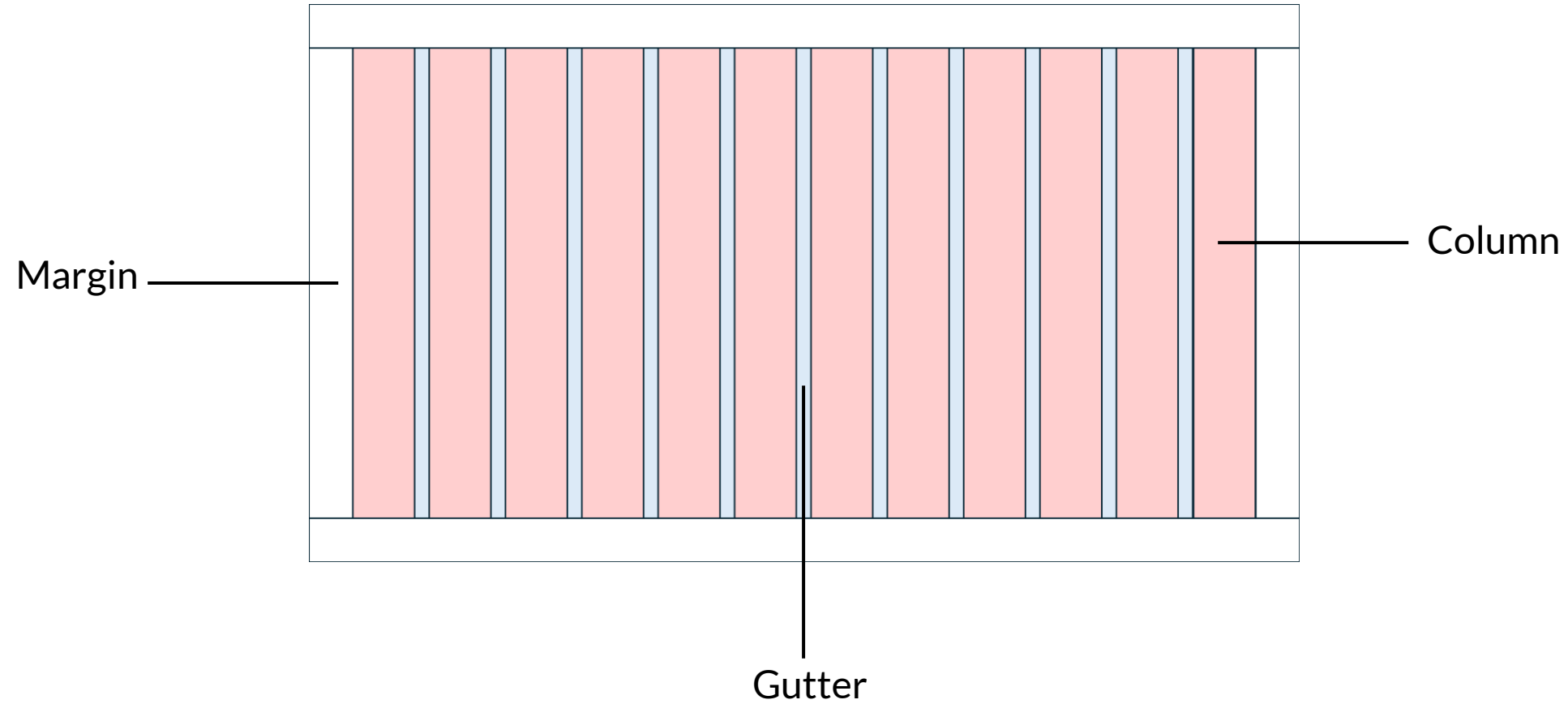
- Establish visual hierarchy
- Improve readability and flow
- Speed up your layout decisions
- Create consistency across multiple pages or screens
- Achieve that *clean, professional look* effortlessly

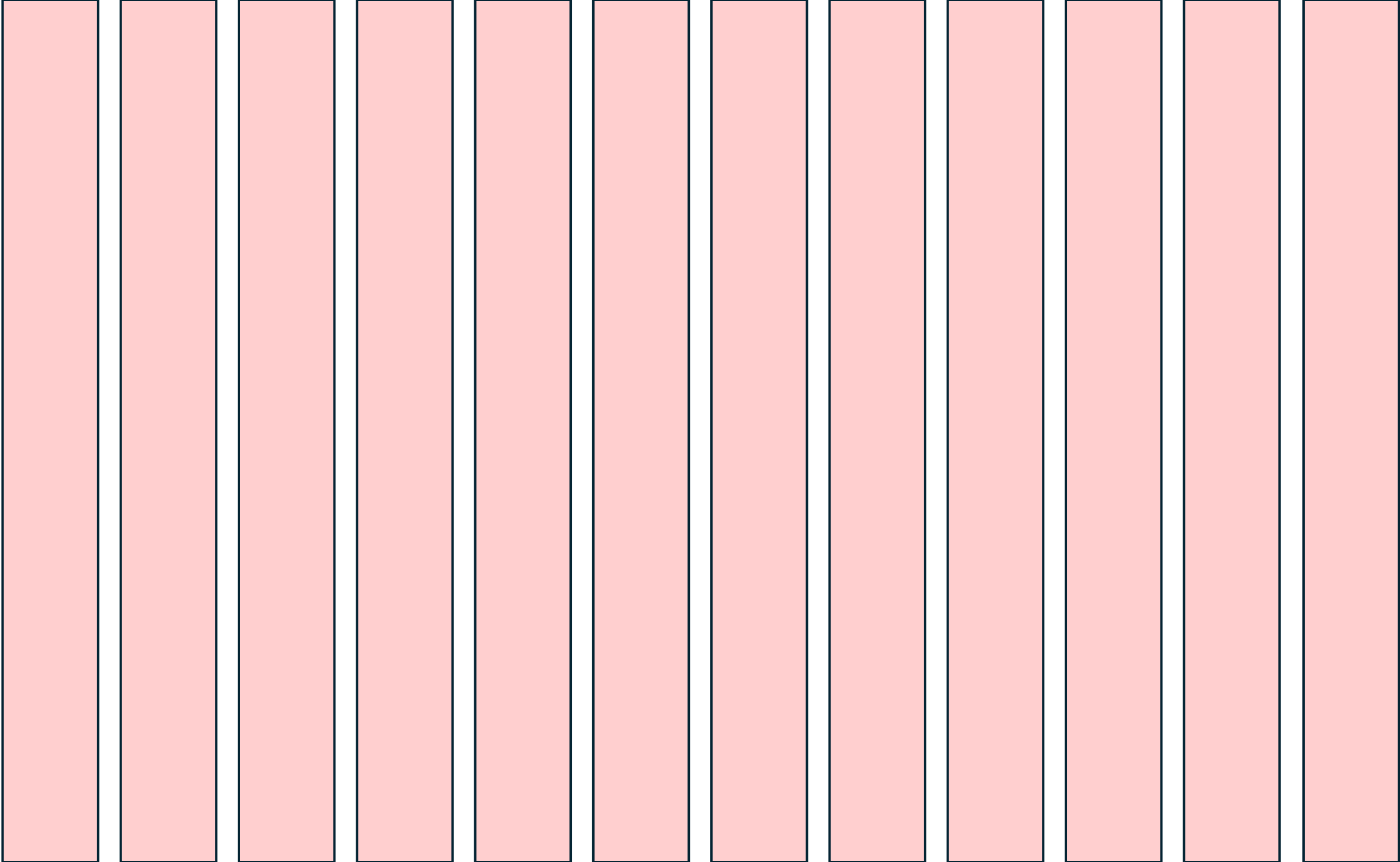
What You Will Build

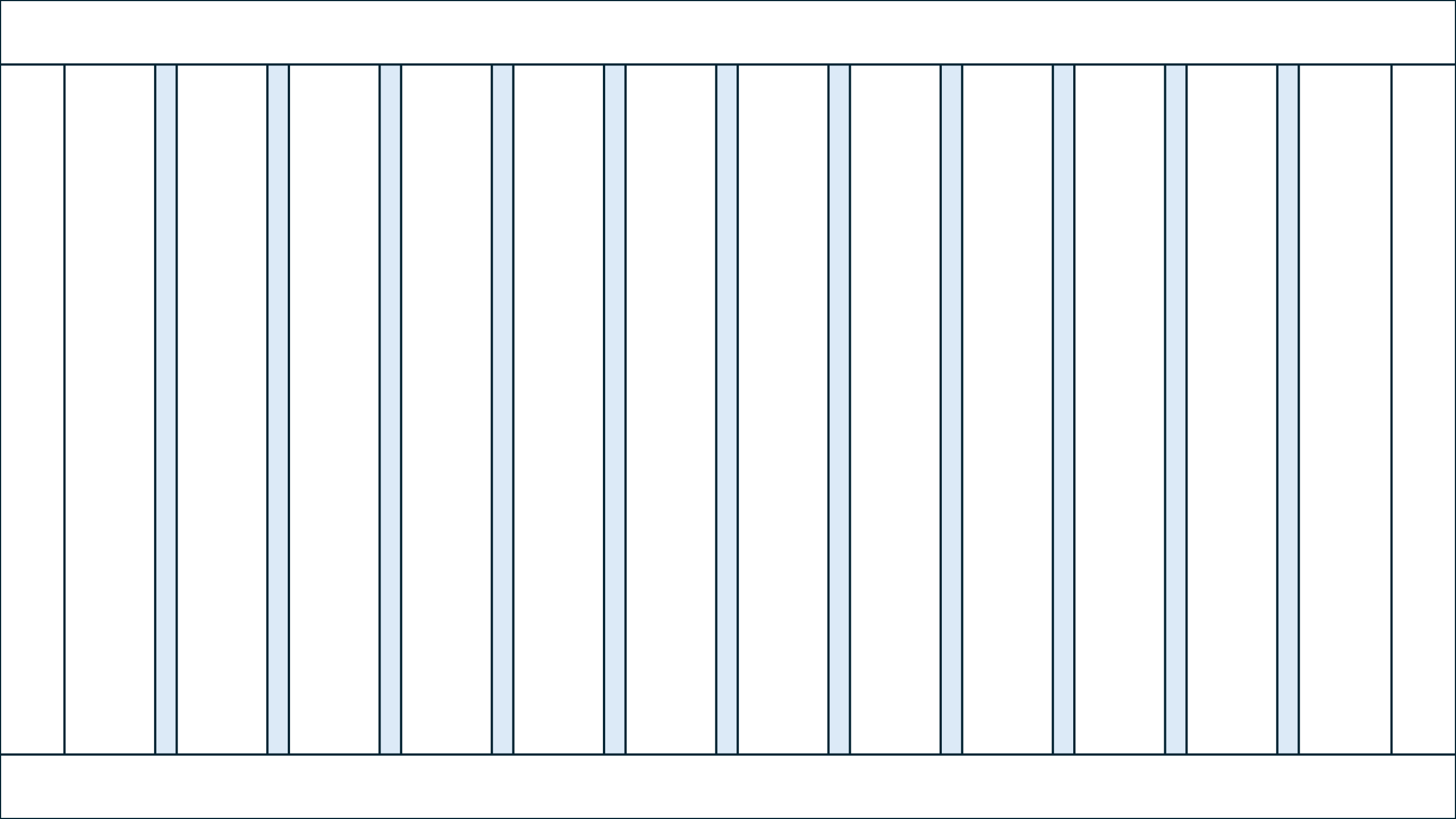
By the end of this workbook, you'll have:

- A fully documented grid system (margins, columns, gutters, baselines).
- A responsive framework for print or digital media.
- A reusable template you can apply to future projects.

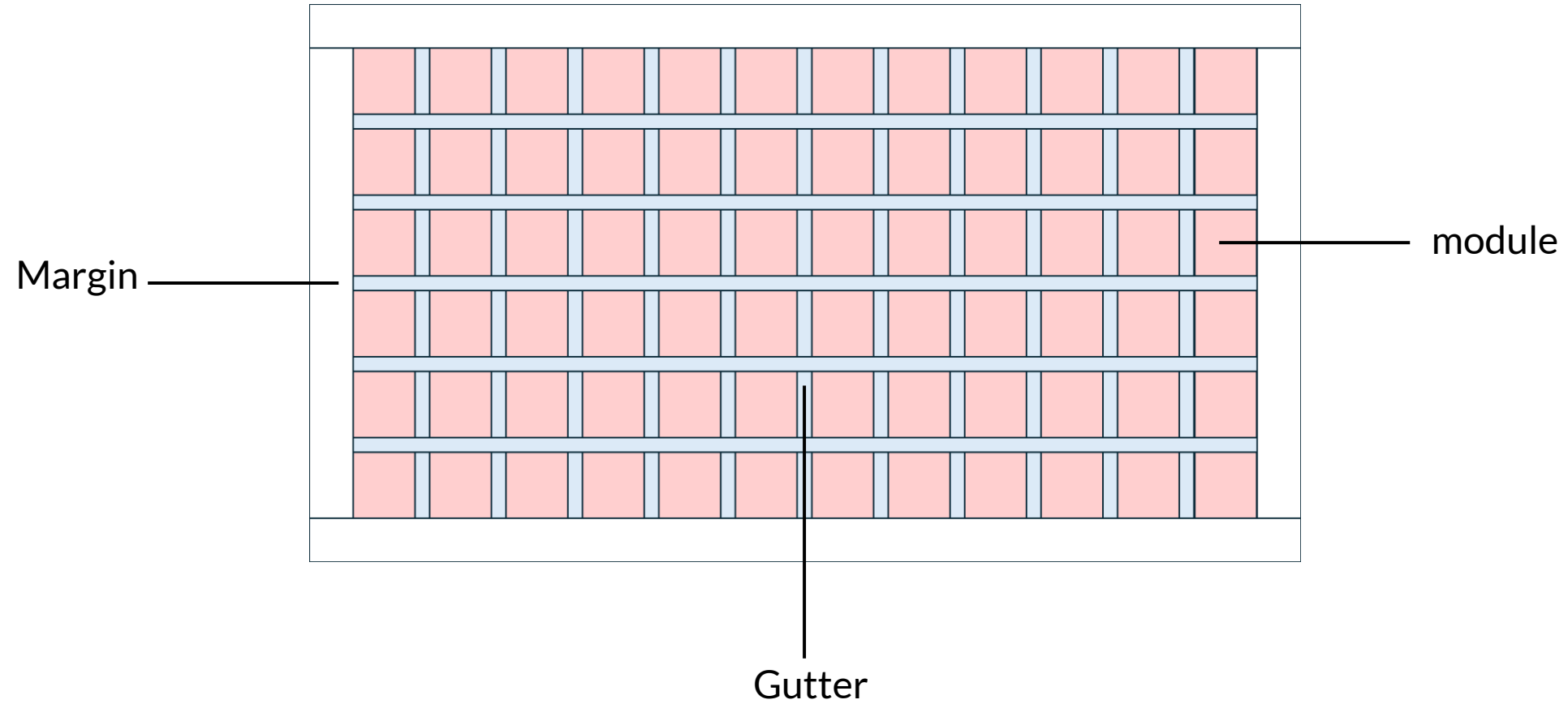
12-column Grid System







12-column Grid System



WHAT IS A 12-COLUMN GRID

Before you build a grid, you need to understand its most popular and flexible form: the **12-column grid**.

A 12-column grid divides a layout into **12 equal-width vertical columns** (plus spaces in between called *gutters*). These columns act as guides to place text, images, buttons, and other elements in a clean, structured way.

Creating a 12-column Grid

A Step-by-Step Picture Guide

Before you start:

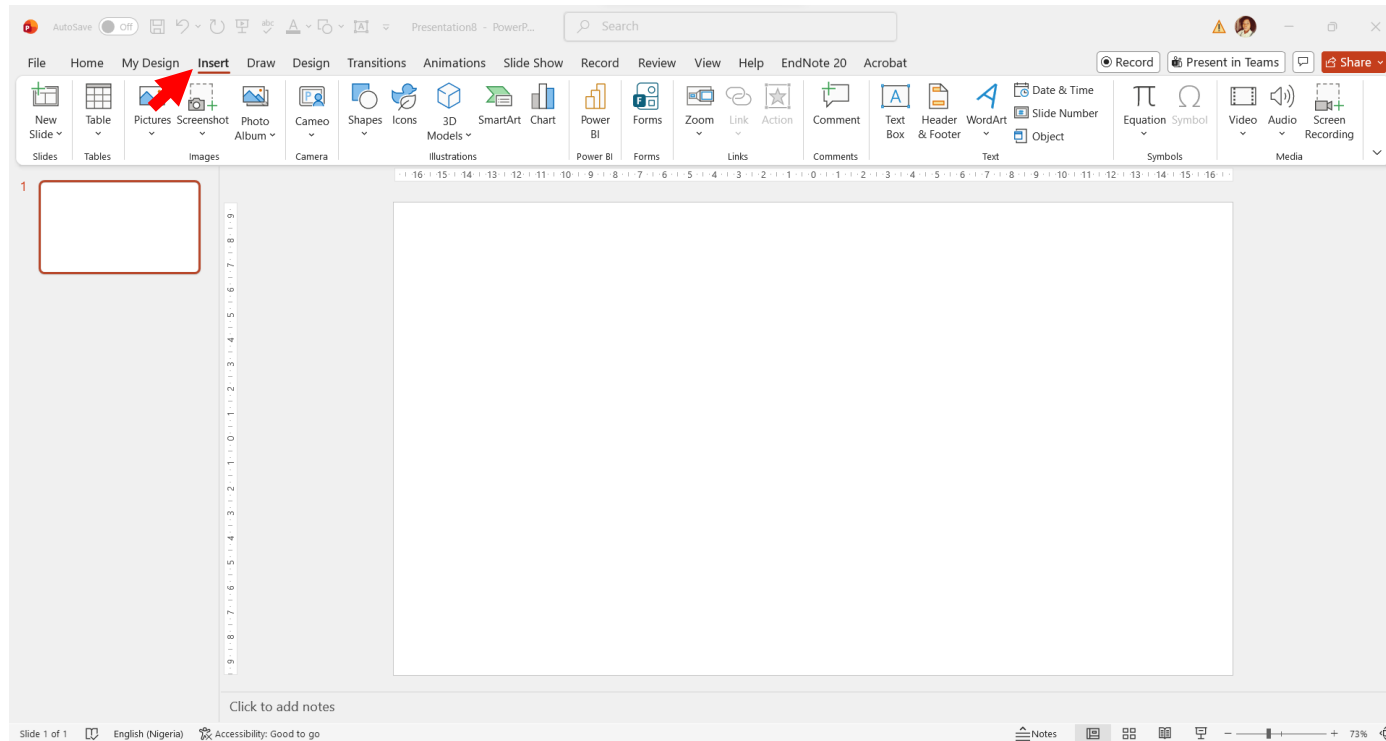
Open PowerPoint. Start with a **blank slide**.

Make sure the **ruler** and **guides** are off for now (we will use only rectangles).

STEP 1 — Find your screen size

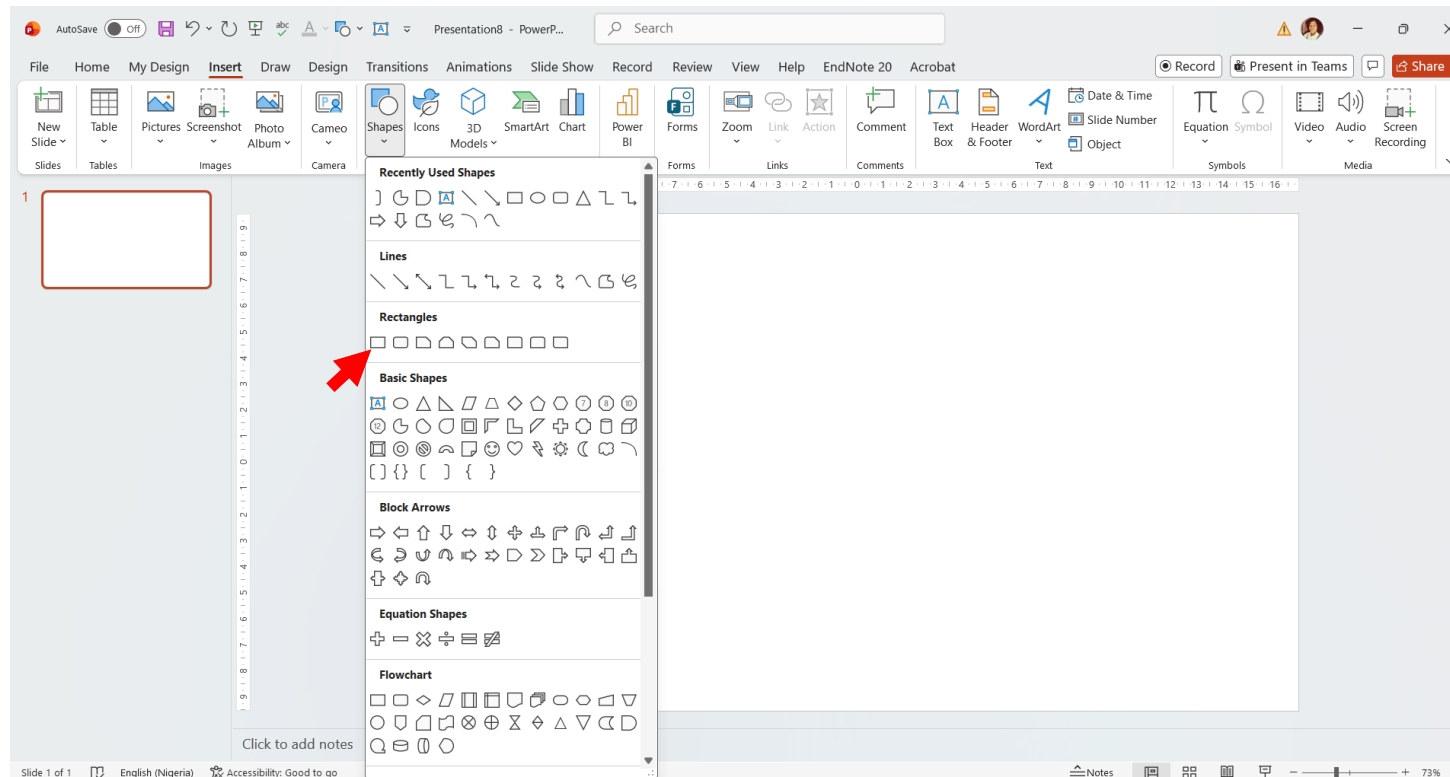
What to do:

Click on the **Insert** tab (top menu).



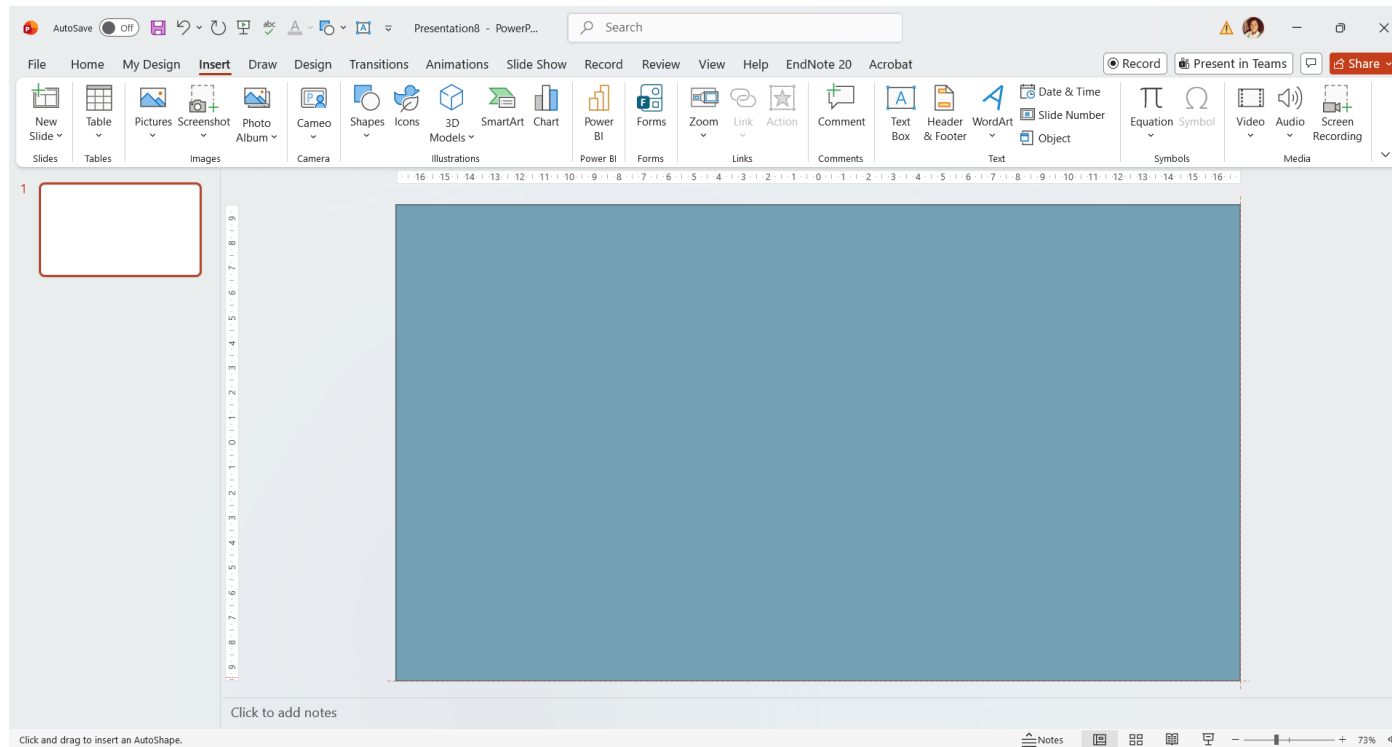
STEP 1 — Find your screen size

Click **Shapes** → choose the **Rectangle** (first one).



STEP 1 – Find your screen size

Draw a rectangle **over the whole slide** from top-left corner to bottom-right corner.



STEP 1 – Find your screen size

With the rectangle selected, look at the top-right of PowerPoint window. You will see **Width** and **Height** numbers.

Write them down here:

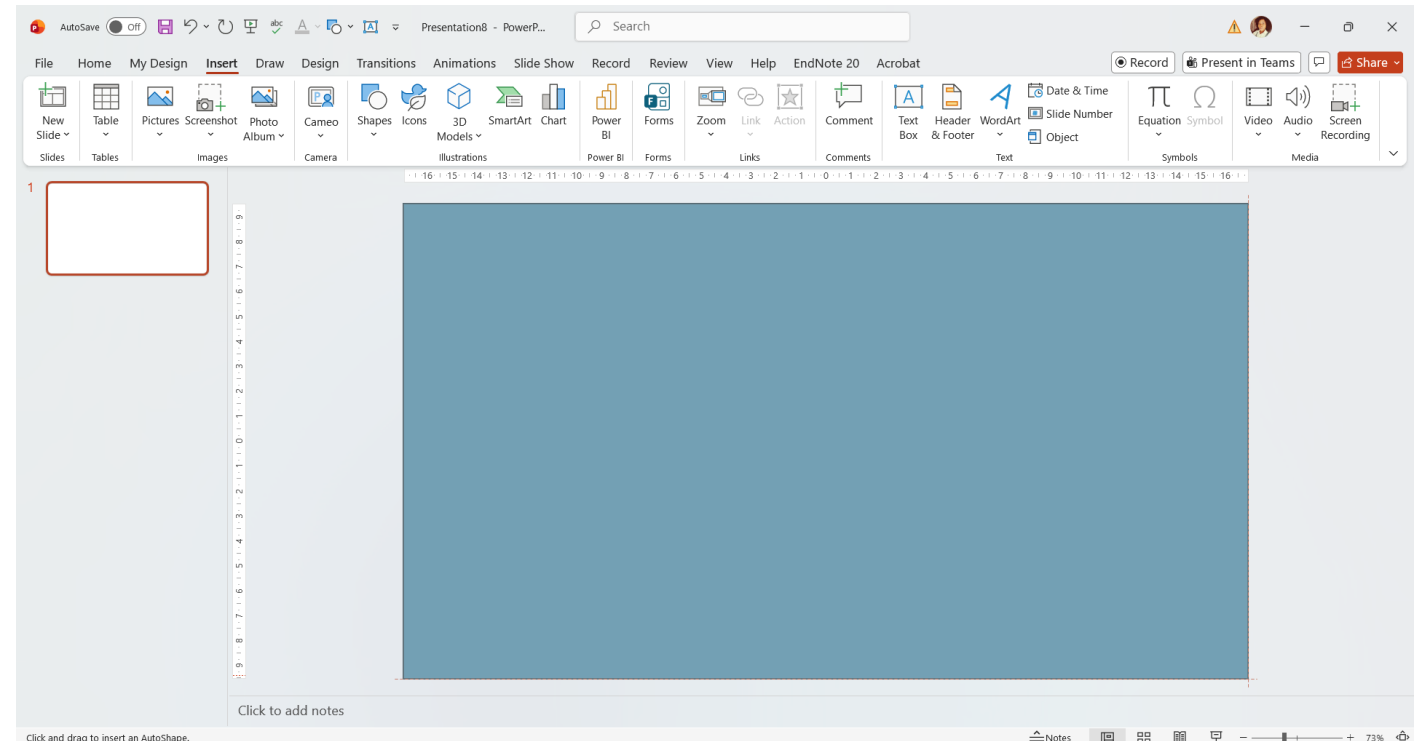
Total width = _____ cm

Total height = _____ cm

 *Example from one screen:*

Width = 33.87 cm

Height = 19.05 cm



STEP 2 – Create your margins

Margins keep your content from touching the edge of the screen.
We will use;

- **1.5 cm** for the **left margin**
- **1.5 cm** for the **right margin**
- **1.5 cm** for the **top margin**
- **1.5 cm** for the **bottom margin**

STEP 2 – Create your margins

What to do:

Left margin:

Go to **Insert** → **Shapes** → **Rectangle**

Draw a tall skinny rectangle on the **left edge** of your slide.

Click on the rectangle.

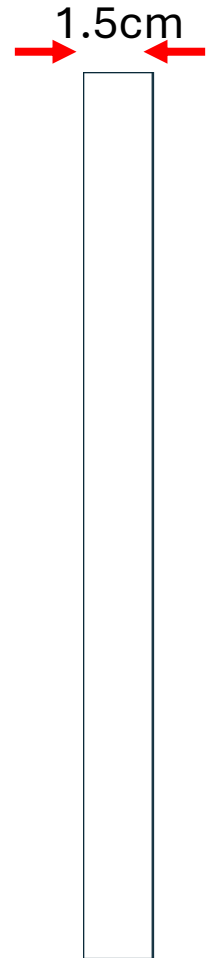
In the top-left corner (Width/Height box):

Set **Width** = **1.5 cm**

Set **Height** = **same as your total screen height** (example: 19.05 cm)

Move it so it touches the left edge perfectly.

STEP 2 – Create your margins-one side



STEP 2 – Create your margins

What to do:

Right margin:

Repeat the same steps on the **right edge**.

Width = 1.5 cm, Height = total screen height.

STEP 2 – Create your margins- 2 sides



STEP 2 – Create your margins

What to do:

Top margin:

Draw a short wide rectangle at the **top** of the slide.

Width = total screen width (example: 33.87 cm)

Height = 1.5 cm

Bottom margin:

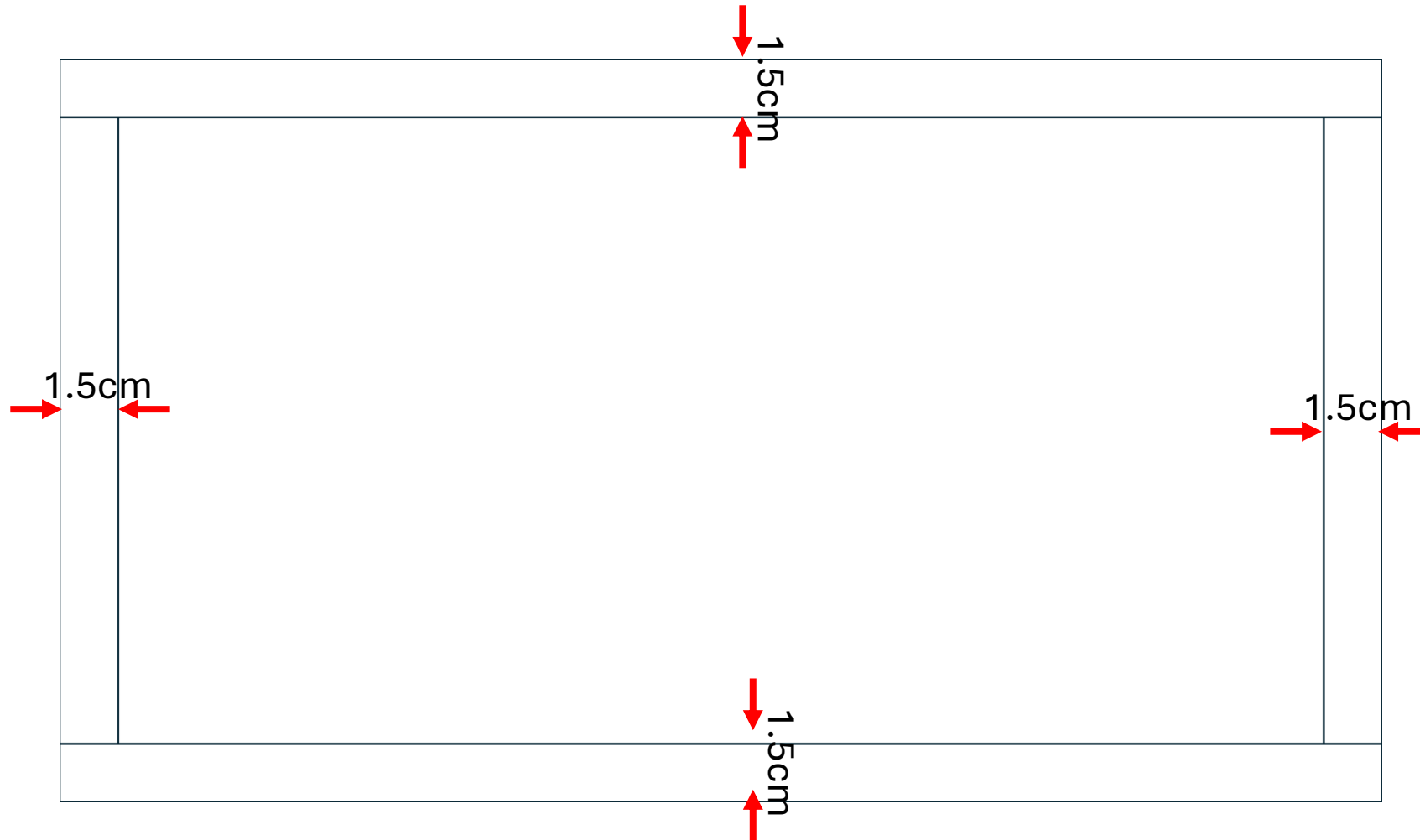
Same as top, but at the **bottom**.

Width = total screen width

Height = 1.5 cm

Now you have four margin rectangles around your slide.

STEP 2 – Create your margins- 4 sides



STEP 3- Group and color your margin

- Click on your margin rectangle and select all four, then select Ctrl on windows or command on mac and select “G” (Ctrl G to group)
- Name it “Margin”
- Go to **Shape Fill** , select margin, top right, click on shape format and select fill(top menu, paint bucket icon).
- Choose **White**.
- Repeat for all four margin rectangles.

STEP 4 – Create your first column

- We will use:
- 12 columns
- 11 gutters (spaces between columns)
- Each gutter = 0.5 cm wide
- Column width = unknown (we calculate it)

Formula (Skip if you are not interested)

Total width = (left margin + right margin) + (12 × column width) + (11 × gutter width)

- Example with numbers:
- $33.87 = (1.5 + 1.5) + (12 \times \text{column width}) + (11 \times 0.5)$
- $33.87 = 3 + (12 \times \text{column width}) + 5.5$
- $33.87 - 8.5 = 12 \times \text{column width}$
- $25.37 = 12 \times \text{column width}$
- Column width = 2.11 cm
-  Your column width = 2.11 cm

STEP 4 – Create your first column

What to do (first column):

- Insert → Shapes → Rectangle
- Draw a tall rectangle anywhere.
- Set Width = 2.11 cm
- Set Height = total screen height
- Example: 19.05
- Place it so it touches the left margin on its left side.



2.11cm

The diagram shows a large rectangular area defined by a dark blue border. On the left side, there is a vertical red strip. A dimension line with arrows at both ends is positioned to the left of the red strip, indicating its width. The text '2.11cm' is placed above the dimension line.

STEP 5 – Create one gutter next to the column

Insert → Shapes → Rectangle

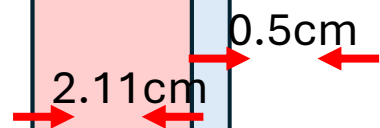
Draw a tall skinny rectangle.

Set **Width** = 0.5 cm

Set **Height** = same as column height

Place it **directly to the right** of your first column, touching it.

✓ Now you have: **[Column] [Gutter]**.



2.11cm

0.5cm

The diagram shows two vertical bars on a white background. The left bar is light red and the right bar is light blue. Both bars are outlined in black. Red double-headed arrows indicate the width of each bar. The red bar's width is labeled '2.11cm' and the blue bar's width is labeled '0.5cm'. The labels are positioned to the left of their respective bars.

STEP 6 – Duplicate to fill the whole screen

This is the magic trick to avoid drawing 12 times.

Select both the column and the gutter (click one, hold Ctrl, click the other).

Press **Ctrl + C** (copy)

Press **Ctrl + V** (paste)

Drag the new pair so it sits **right after** the first gutter.

Repeat paste and drag until you have **12 columns and 11 gutters**.

 *Stop when the last column touches the right margin.*

STEP 7 – Group and Color Your column and Gutters

Columns:

Click on any column rectangle.

Shape Fill → choose **Pink**

Transparency → **70%**

Repeat for all columns (use Ctrl+click to select multiple)

Gutters:

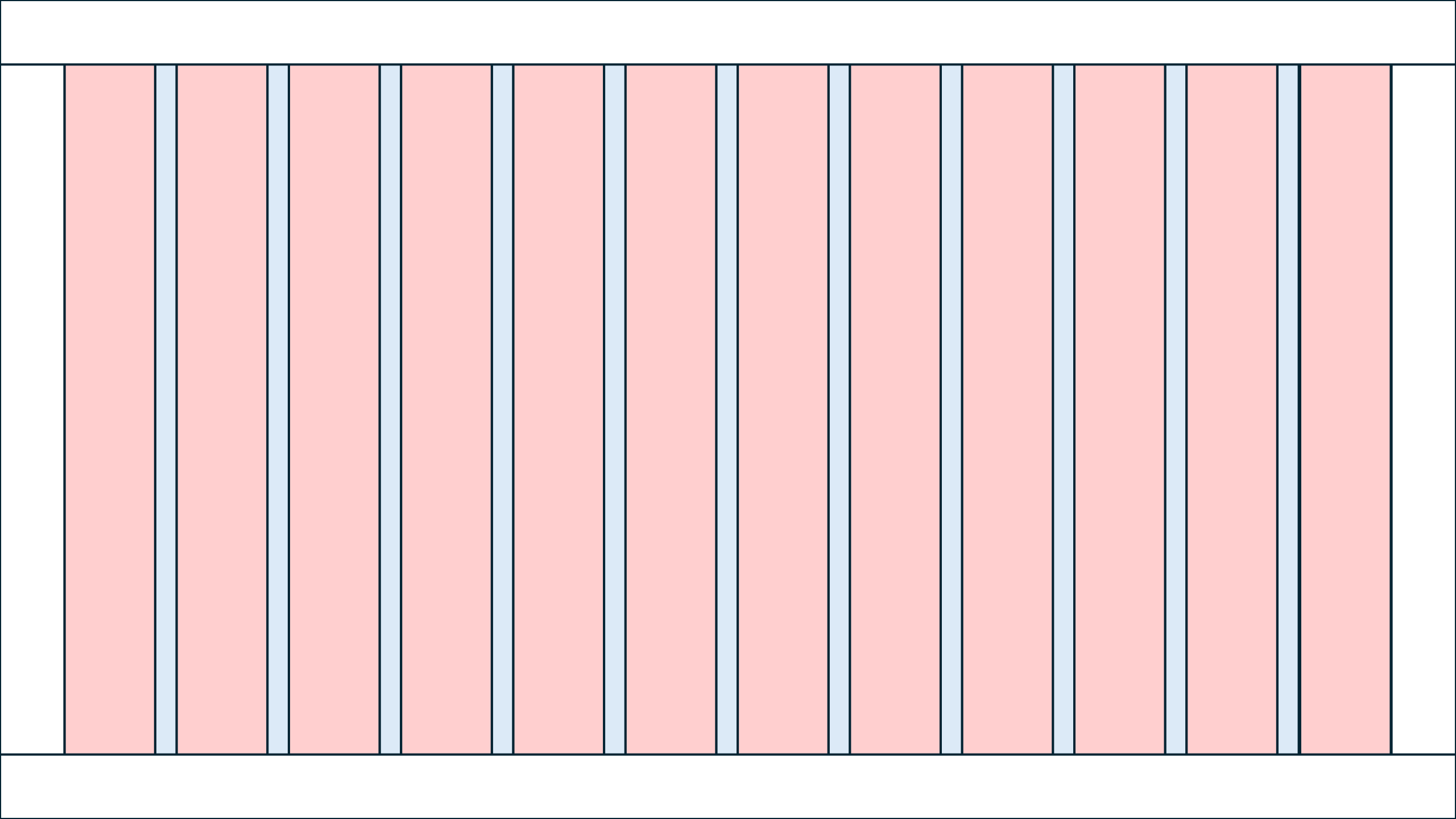
Click on any gutter rectangle.

Shape Fill → choose **Blue**

Transparency → **70%**

Repeat for all gutters.

Margins = white, Columns = pink, Gutters = blue, Rows (next) = no fill.



STEP 8 – Create Rows

We use:

6 rows

5 horizontal gutters

Gutter height = 0.5 cm

Row height = unknown

STEP 8 – Calculate Row height (optional)

Total height = top margin + bottom margin + (6 × row height) + (5 × gutter height)

Example: $19.05 = 3 + (6 \times \text{row height}) + (5 \times 0.5)$

$19.05 = 3 + (6 \times \text{row height}) + 2.5$

$19.05 - 5.5 = 6 \times \text{row height}$

$13.55 = 6 \times \text{row height}$

Row height = 2.26 cm

 **Your row height = 2.26 cm**

STEP 8 – Create Row

What to do:

Insert → Shapes → Rectangle

Draw a short wide rectangle.

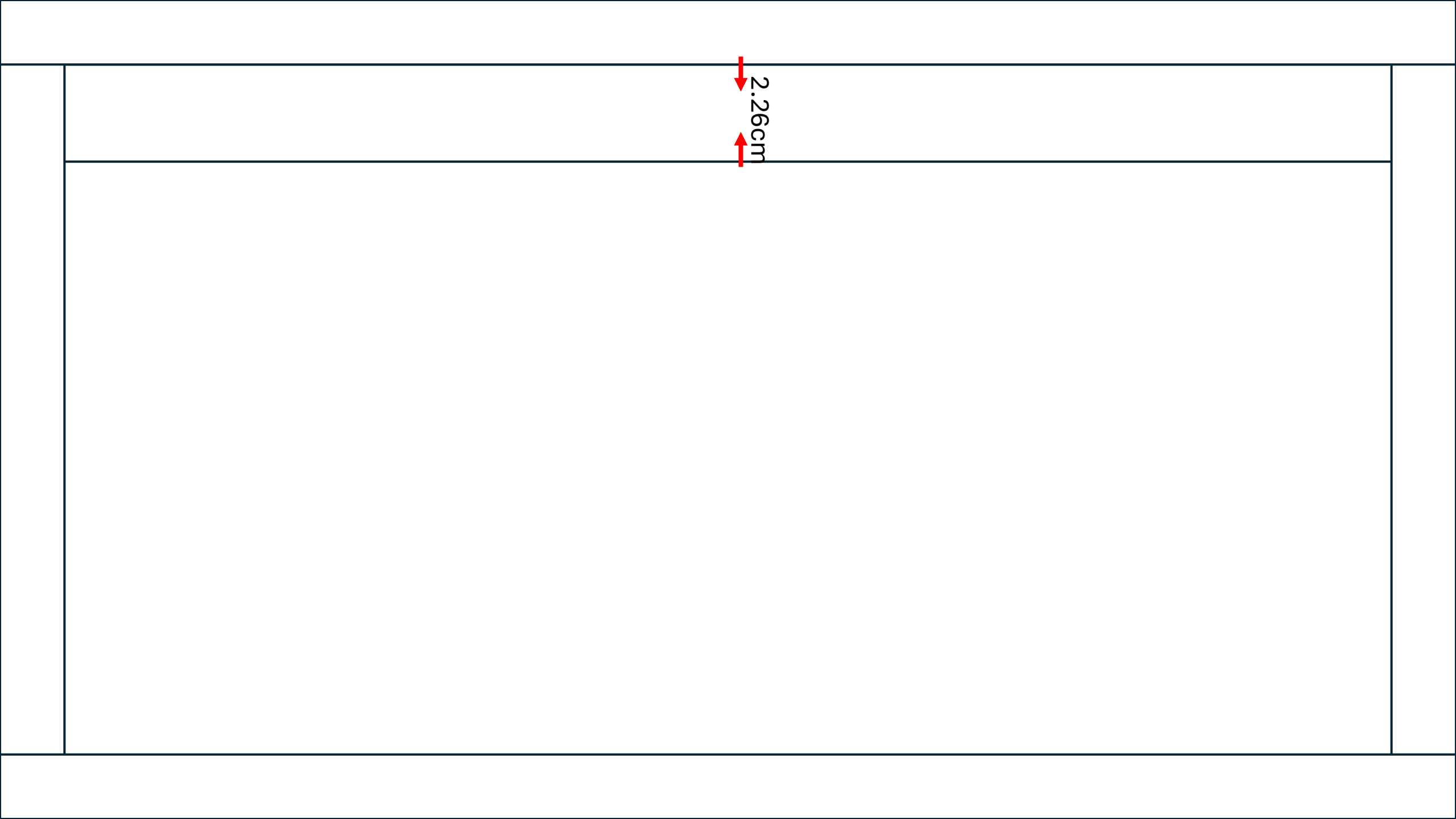
Set **Height = 2.26 cm**

Set **Width = total screen width** (example: 33.87 cm)

Place it directly **below the top margin**.

No fill (leave transparent, or use a very light color at 70% if needed).

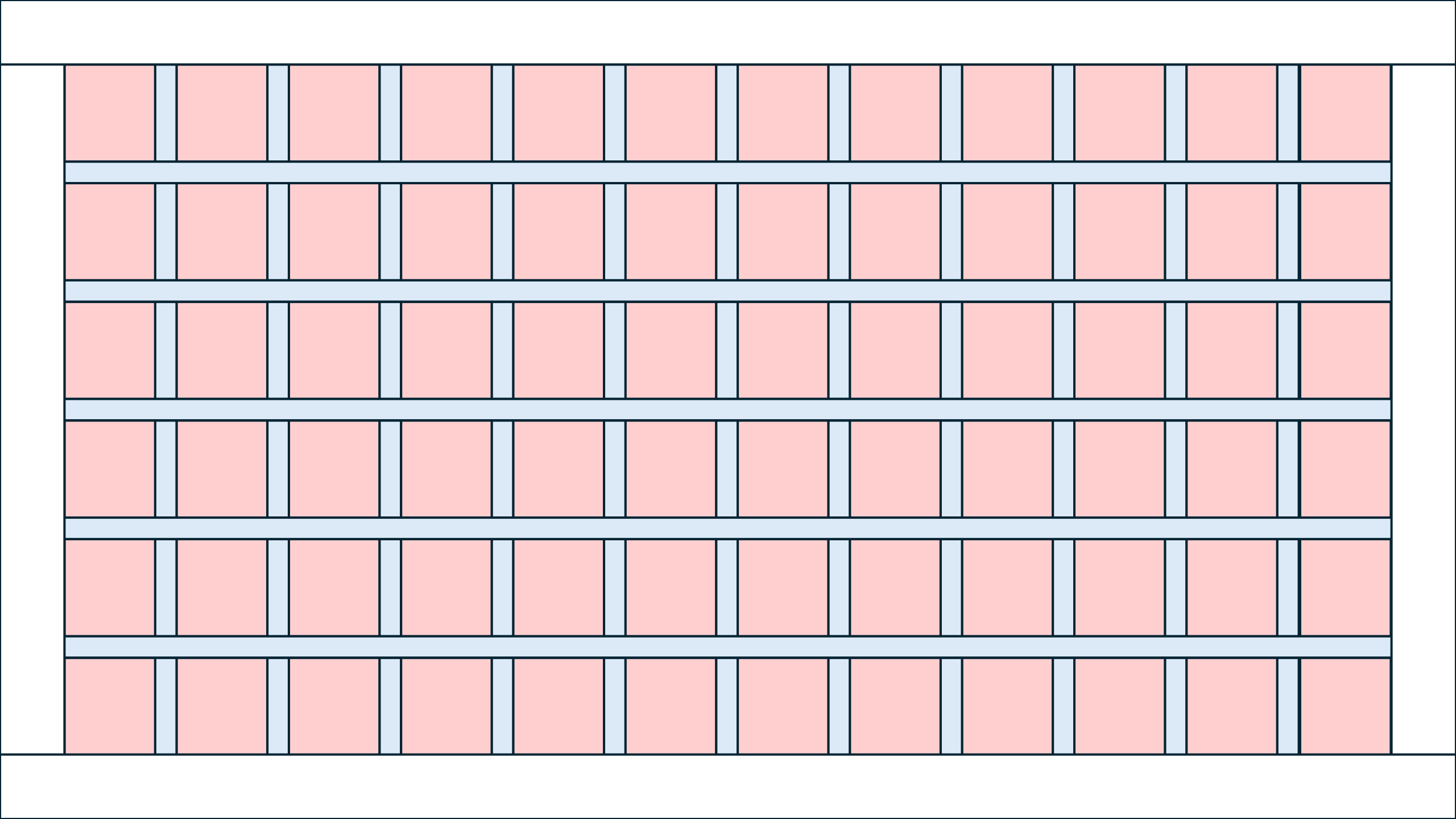
Repeat to make 6 rows stacked vertically, each **2.26 cm tall**, with a **0.5 cm gap** between them (that gap is your horizontal gutter, you can draw it as a thin rectangle or just leave empty space).



2.26cm

A diagram of a rectangular frame with a light gray background. The frame is defined by dark gray lines. A dimension line is shown at the top, consisting of two horizontal lines with red arrows pointing towards each other. The text '2.26cm' is written vertically between these two lines.





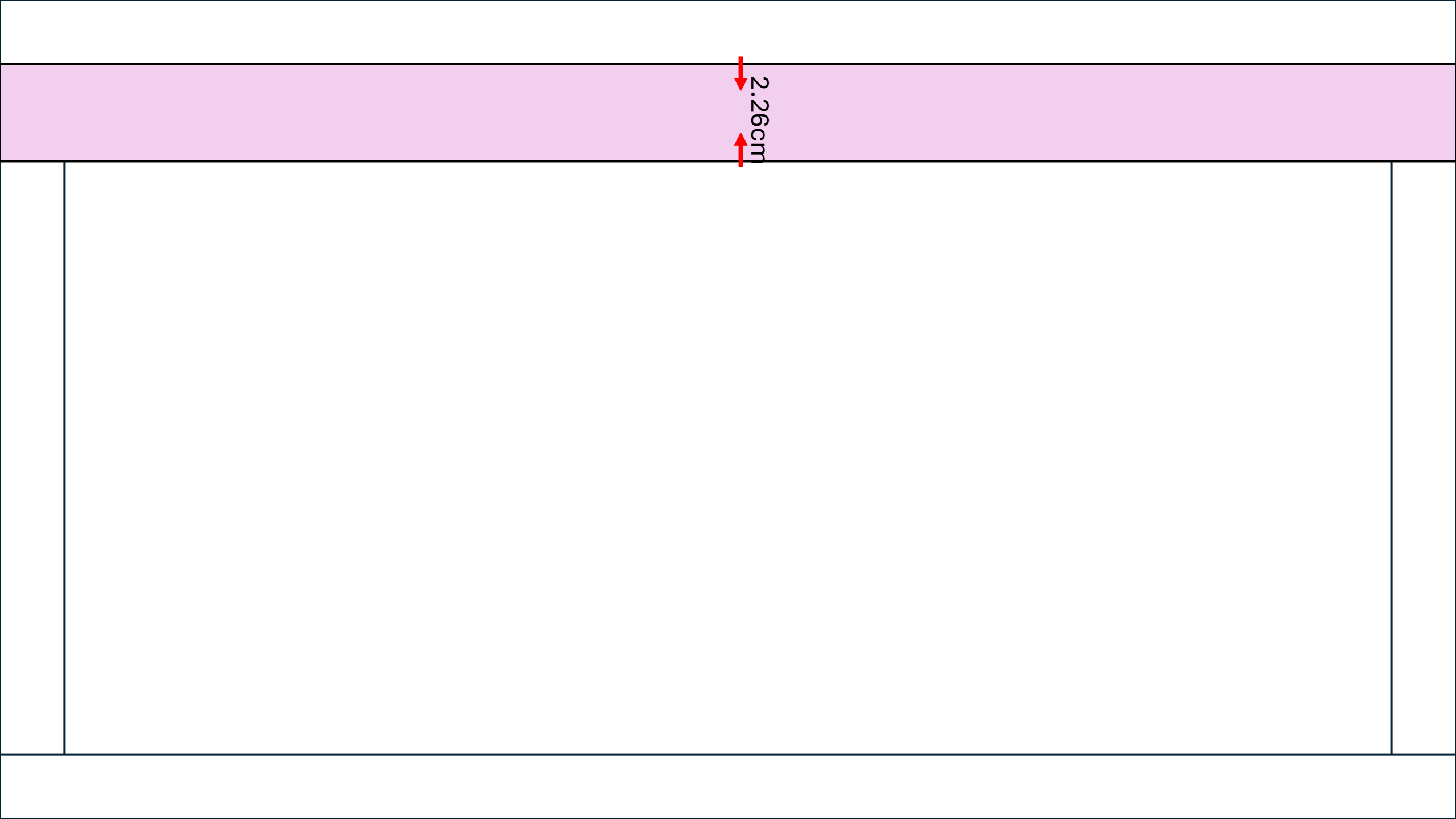
STEP 9 – Create baseline for text alignment

A baseline helps you align text neatly inside a row.

Each row = 2.26 cm tall

Divide each row into **8 equal parts**

Each part (sub-row height) = $2.26 \div 8 = 0.28$ cm



STEP 9 – Create baseline for text alignment

What to do:

Inside the **first row**, draw a very short rectangle.

Set **Height** = 0.28 cm

Set **Width** = **same as row width** (total screen width minus left and right margins)

Place it at the **top of the row** (touching the top edge of the row).

Color = **very light grey or no fill** (just as a guide).

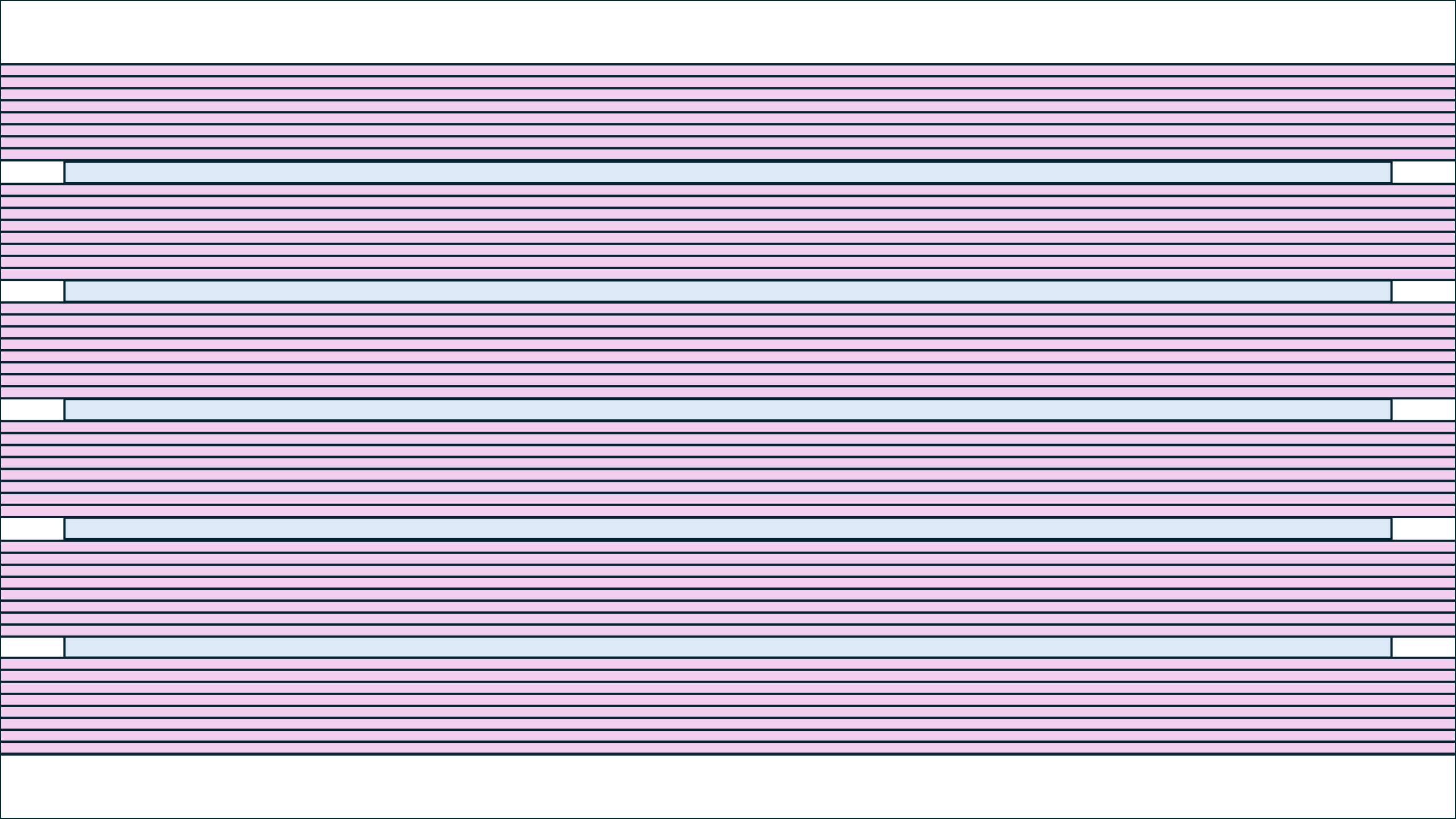
Duplicate it 7 more times inside the same row, each **0.28 cm tall**, stacked without gaps.

Repeat the same for all 6 rows.

✓ *Now every row has 8 thin baselines for your text.*

[illegible]

[illegible]



Final Step- You are done!

You have built:

- ✓ 1.5 cm margins (white)
- ✓ 12 columns (pink, 70%)
- ✓ 11 vertical gutters (blue, 70%)
- ✓ 6 rows (transparent)
- ✓ 5 horizontal gutters (0.5 cm each)
- ✓ Baselines inside each row (0.28 cm each)

Now, save your file as my custom Grid.

